HANDOUT 1 · MCENERNEY-LENS

Expert Academic Writing Methods

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Compiled from *The Craft of Writing Effectively*, a Leadership Lab lecture by Larry McEnerney (University of Chicago Writing Program); recording posted 26 June 2014. Unofficial study handout: time stamps such as [31:34] point to the recording.

1 Writing Philosophy Overview

- Academic writing is not about rules; it's about **readers**. [2:59–3:54]
- The purpose of writing is not to convey what you think *but to change what your readers think*. [21:22–22:07]
- Your writing succeeds only if it is perceived as **valuable** by a specific community of readers. [14:08–16:24]
- Value is defined *not* in the content itself but by how readers use or respond to it. [15:27–16:31]
- Knowledge is a conversation that moves through time, not a pile that grows with every new fact. The community decides what counts as knowledge, and ideas also get left behind; new information it does not care about is not knowledge. ADDED [28:03–30:51]

2 Core Methods for Effective Academic Writing

M1 Value-Oriented Writing 22:13–34:10

- Ask not *what do I want to say?* but *why should my readers care?* [22:13–22:38]
- Use language that signals value: words like *nonetheless*, *however*, *although*, *inconsistent*, *anomaly*, *reported*, *widely*, *accepted*. [31:28–32:21]
- Spend 15 minutes a week reading articles in your field and **circling value-signaling words**. Build your own word bank. [32:27–34:10]

M2 Know Your Readers 16:37–17:10; 34:46–35:20; 1:00:57

- Understand the beliefs, assumptions, and doubts of your specific disciplinary audience. [34:46–35:20]
- Avoid generic writing aimed at abstract or standardized readers (e.g., SAT/AP). [16:45–17:10]
- Learn how your target journals express **costs** (what's at stake) and **benefits** (what is gained). [1:00:57–1:02:37]

M3 Constructing Problems Effectively 37:24–38:40; 55:19–59:05

- Shift from background or definitions to **instability** or **tension**. [55:19–56:25; 58:42]
- Build problems that **matter to your readers**, not problems of personal interest. [56:45–58:07]
- Problems should challenge assumptions or practices in the field. [37:24–38:40]

M4 Argument vs. Explanation 20:18–24:48; 40:23–40:48

- Do not *explain to show what you know*; **argue to change what your readers think**. [20:18–20:57; 40:23]
- Explanation is inward-facing. Argumentation is outward-facing. [20:57–21:17]
- Predict and overcome reader doubts. Your goal is not self-revelation but persuasion. [35:09; 40:29–40:48]

M5 Literature Reviews as Problem Builders 1:03:14–1:10:45

- A professional literature review enriches the **problem**, rather than listing chronologically who said what. [1:04:52–1:05:23]
- Highlight tensions, contradictions, or conflicts between works. [1:05:23–1:06:43]
- Avoid the *gap model* ("this hasn't been done"). Prefer the **error model** ("this has been done, but there's a problem"). [1:08:47–1:10:45]

M6 Two Kinds of Value Words ADDED 35:27–37:12; 53:35–54:52

- **Community words** such as *widely*, *accepted* and *reported* show that a community of readers already cares about the question. [35:27–35:55]
- **Instability words** such as *nonetheless*, *however*, *although*, *inconsistent* and *anomaly* show that something in that community's understanding is unstable. They create tension, whatever their part of speech. [53:35–54:52]
- **Flow words** such as *because*, *and*, *if* and *unless* make prose flow but create no value. Don't count them as value words. [36:15–37:12]
- *Rarely* ("has rarely been scrutinized") is often code for a gap claim. [1:10:53–1:10:59]

M7 Value Before Explanation ADDED 19:52–25:13

- Your readers' professional function is to challenge what you say: nothing is accepted as knowledge until someone competent has challenged it. [23:16–24:27]
- Explanation belongs only after value has been established and persuasion has begun. [24:27–24:48]
- Don't open with a definition. It shows a teacher that you know it; it gives a professional reader nothing. [25:00–25:13]
- When readers say your work doesn't seem important, or that they didn't understand it, don't respond by explaining more. [19:52–20:23]

M8 Openings That Show a Problem ADDED 55:19–1:00:37; 1:07:55

- Avoid the “martini glass” opening: a generalization, then a thesis, then a generalization again. [55:47–56:19]
- Readers scan an opening for instability. Language of continuity and consistency there interferes with their reading, and they can stop two paragraphs in. [59:05–1:00:37]
- A thesis is a solution only if readers can see the problem it solves, so the problem must be stated. [58:12–58:36]
- Locate the problem in something readers care about: for academic readers, something they want to understand; for other readers, something they want to fix. [57:22–58:07]
- When readers ask for “more background,” they usually mean they can’t see why it matters. The background they need is a problem. [1:07:55–1:08:21]

M9 Saying “You’re Wrong” in the Community’s Code ADDED 39:05–44:13

- “I have something to add” invites the reply “we don’t care.” Showing that the community has something wrong gives it a reason to listen. [41:16–41:51]
- Every community has a polite code for “you’re wrong,” often deferential: you have advanced this field, but there is one thing here that is wrong. Learn how your journals say it. [39:05–40:14; 43:50–44:02]
- Break the code and you get slapped down; skip the move altogether and you get rejected. [44:02–44:13]

M10 Raising the Costs in a Literature Review ADDED 1:04:21–1:06:43; 1:09:49

- Credibility and acknowledging the community’s work are real functions of a literature review too. [1:04:21–1:04:41]
- The strongest reviews raise the costs: the tension matters because the community has kept building on it, so “we” are wrong too, not only earlier authors. [1:06:05–1:06:43]
- Gap claims assume knowledge is bounded, like a crossword puzzle. If knowledge is open-ended, filling one gap leaves countless others, so the claim adds little. [1:09:49–1:10:45]

3 Common Pitfalls to Avoid

- Thinking writing is about expressing your thoughts—it’s about changing others’ thoughts. [21:30–22:07; 49:22]
- Starting with personal curiosity or background instead of the reader’s problem. [56:45–57:22; 1:08:07]
- Believing that “originality” guarantees value. **Value comes from relevance to the reader.** [25:26–30:58]
- Assuming your writing will “preserve ideas forever.” The goal is participation, not permanence. [46:45–48:58]

4 Action Items: Reading an Article in Your Field

Read the whole article, not only the introduction: problems, stakes, value and doubts are often stated again, or stated more sharply, in later sections (R6). Fields L1–L10 cover the whole paper; for each, record what the text does and where, in whichever section it appears. *Draws on* names the methods behind each field.

L1 **Identify the readers:** Two parts. *Research community*: whose understanding does the paper set out to change? Interdisciplinary work has several communities, and each defines problems and judges arguments differently. *Wider readers*: who could use the work to fix something, such as practitioners or engineers? Note the journal it is published in. Draws on M2, M8.
[34:46; 57:22–58:07; 1:12:19–1:14:04]

L2 **Circle value words, in context:** Quote each value word in its sentence, with the word in bold. Sort it as an instability word (*however*, *nonetheless*, *inconsistent*, *problematic*, *anomaly*) or a community word (*widely*, *accepted*, *reported*). Flow words don't count; *gap* and *rarely* often signal a gap claim. Where a sentence is worth reusing, add its frame: the sentence with the paper's specifics replaced by slots. Draws on M1, M6 and the Bonus Tip. [31:34–34:10; 35:27–37:12; 53:35–54:52]

L3 **Name the value offered:** ADDED What do the authors say readers gain, overall? Quote the sentence that says it. A type label, such as verification, method, benchmark, correction, theory or practical use, is your interpretation, so mark it as one. Draws on M1, M2. [15:27–16:31; 1:00:57–1:02:37]

L4 **Find the problem:** State it in three parts, each with its location. *Current state*: what the community does or believes. *Where it breaks*: each approach or assumption, and how it fails. *What remains open*: the question the paper answers. Is the problem explicit or implicit? Draws on M3, M8. [56:25–59:05]

L5 **Read the stance toward prior work:** Who do the authors say got the problem wrong: the dominant view, rival approaches, or the community itself? Do they say it directly, or deferentially, crediting the work before naming its limit? Draws on M9, M10. [39:05–44:13; 1:16:43]

L6 **Find the stakes:** What does the text say it costs to ignore the problem, and what is gained by solving it? Note whether the cost is stated as a cost to these readers (their predictions, results or decisions) or only as a fact about the world. Draws on M2, M10. [1:00:57–1:02:21; 1:06:05–1:06:43]

L7 **Find the doubts answered:** ADDED Which reader doubts does the paper anticipate, such as limitations, validation or "one might argue," and where does it answer them? Draws on M4, M7. [23:16–24:27; 35:09; 40:29–40:48]

L8 **Find the contribution:** What does the paper offer in response to the problem? Is it named as something readers can use (a tool, a test, a method) or only as an activity ("X is analyzed")? Draws on M1, M8. [58:12–58:36]

L9 **Map the structure:** Does the paper build from instability: the problem, then prior work that sharpens it, then the contribution? Do the discussion and conclusion return to the problem? Does explanation (definitions, background, method) come only after value is established? Does the literature review build the problem or list who said what, and does it argue by the error model or the gap model? Draws on M3, M5, M7, M8. [24:27–25:13; 55:19–56:19; 1:04:52–1:10:45]

L10 **Check the pitfalls:** ADDED Run four checks, each drawn from a Common Pitfall (Section 3, in brackets), and report each as found, quoted with its location, or not found.

- *Background opening* (starting with background): the introduction's first paragraph has no instability word. Either way, note where the first one appears.
- *The writers' interest as the reason* (starting with personal curiosity): a sentence gives the authors' interest or aim ("we are interested in," "this study aims to explore") before the introduction

states any problem.

- *Originality as the value* (believing originality guarantees value): "novel," "new," "first" or "for the first time" is offered as the reason to read, and the same paragraph does not say what it changes for readers.
- *Results without consequence* (expressing your thoughts instead of changing the readers'): a results, discussion or conclusion paragraph says what a figure, table or case shows, and neither it nor the next paragraph says what that changes for the problem (L4) or for the readers.

The fourth pitfall, writing to preserve ideas, is a belief that doesn't show in a text, so it has no check. Draws on M4, M8. [21:30–22:07; 25:26–30:58; 56:45–57:22]

For your own draft (self-check)

L11 **Count value words:** ADDED Can you circle about ten value words in your first two paragraphs? If not, go back to your word bank. For a self-check status, count distinct community and instability words (M6; flow words don't count): 8 or more is STRONG, 4–7 PARTIAL, 3 or fewer MISSING. Draws on M1, M6. [34:04–34:18]

L12 **Revise the opening last:** ADDED Does your first sentence state the problem the paper ended up solving? Check it against L4: if a later section states the problem more sharply, the opening should carry it. Writers often find their problem late, sometimes only from a final reader. Draws on M8. [1:18:46–1:19:39]

Figures and tables are locations, not a separate field. When a figure shows the problem, the stakes or the value, for example the accepted view failing, cite it in that field. [1:14:53–1:15:20]

> **Bonus Tip:** Maintain a personal glossary of high-value vocabulary and sentence structures from journal articles. [33:45–34:10]

With Handout 2. On one draft, this handout owns the opening's problem, stance, stakes and contribution (L4, L5, L6, L8, L12); Handout 2 (*effective-writing*) then checks only the opening's sentences (EW-5–EW-10), so the opening is not flagged twice.

5 Using the Lens: Dissect or Self-Check ADDED

The lens has two modes. Choose one before you start.

> **Dissect** a paper you are reading: record what it does, and where, for fields L1–L10. A dissection describes the paper; it does not grade it.
>
> **Self-check** a draft you are writing: give every field, L1–L12, a status and one fix move.
>
> **Status key, self-check only:** STRONG does it PARTIAL partly MISSING not at all N/A n/a
>
> **Locations:** section, paragraph and the sentence's first words, e.g. Sec. 2 P3 "Existing EV and PT…"; figures and tables by number, e.g. Fig. 1.

R1 **Choose the mode first.** Dissect a paper you are reading; self-check a draft you are writing.

R2 **Every finding cites a location,** written so the reader can find it: section, paragraph and the sentence's first words. Where sentences are numbered, as in Section 6, sentence numbers do.

R3 **A dissection describes; it never grades.** "Not present" and "stated only in Sec. 5" are facts and

may be reported; statuses and verdicts may not.

R4 **A self-check gives each field one status and at most one fix move,** names the method behind the fix (M1–M10), and leaves numbers, results and technical claims untouched.

R5 **Quotes stay short.** At most one quoted sentence per finding, trimmed to about 25 words.

R6 **Read the whole paper.** ADDED Start with the introduction, then read every section, and record each finding wherever it is stated; its location shows which section that is.

6 Worked Example ADDED

The same short introduction is dissected below as if someone else wrote it, then self-checked as if it were your draft. It is a teaching text written for this handout: the paper and its Figure 1 are invented, while the background in P1–P2 is standard in the LES literature. It is an introduction only, so every location below is in the introduction.

P1 S1 Most LES practitioners close the subgrid stress with an eddy viscosity, and in doing so they assume that energy flows only from the resolved scales to the subgrid scales. S2 A priori tests on filtered DNS data have long shown that this assumption is incomplete: locally, energy also flows back to the resolved scales. S3 Because a positive eddy viscosity is purely dissipative, the model cannot represent this backscatter, and where backscatter is strong the closure drains energy from scales that are in fact gaining it. S4 Figure 1 makes the mismatch visible: the modeled flux is forward everywhere, while the filtered-DNS flux changes sign across the domain.

P2 S1 Two lines of work have addressed backscatter, and each leaves the same question open. S2 Stochastic models add a random forcing whose level is set to match an average backscatter rate; matching an average, however, says little about where reverse transfer occurs. S3 Dynamic procedures can return a negative eddy viscosity, but the resulting instability is commonly removed by clipping or averaging, which discards the very events at issue. S4 Neither approach tells a modeler where their closure is wrong.

P3 S1 This paper gives modelers a tool for answering that question: a local diagnostic that measures the sign and size of interscale energy transfer at each point of a filtered field. S2 Applied to filtered DNS of decaying isotropic turbulence, it shows where an eddy-viscosity closure removes energy that the flow is gaining, so modelers can test their closure where it is most likely to fail. S3 Section 2 defines the diagnostic; Section 3 applies it.

Dissect (fields 1–10)

Field	What the paper does	Where
1- Readers	Research community: LES modelers who close the subgrid stress with an eddy viscosity, plus stochastic modelers and users of dynamic procedures. Wider readers: not named. Venue implied: an LES or turbulence-modeling journal	P1 S1; P2 S2–S3
2- Value words	Instability, e.g. “this assumption is **incomplete**”; “the model **cannot** represent this backscatter”; “matching an average, **however**, says little”; “**Neither** approach tells a modeler where their closure is **wrong**.” Community, e.g. “**Most** LES practitioners”; “have **long shown**”; “is **commonly** removed.” Frame: “[Evidence] has long shown that this assumption is incomplete”	P1 S2; P1 S3; P2 S2; P2 S4; P1 S1; P1 S2; P2 S3
3- Value offered	“so modelers can test their closure where it is most likely to fail.” Label (interpretation): a diagnostic method	P3 S2
4- Problem	Current state: eddy-viscosity closures assume energy flows only to the subgrid scales. Where it breaks: a dissipative closure cannot represent backscatter (Fig. 1); stochastic models match only an average rate; dynamic procedures clip the negative events. Open: where is a modeler’s closure wrong? Explicit	P1 S1; P1 S2–S4; P2 S2–S3; P2 S4
5- Stance	Direct toward the dominant practice (“incomplete”); credits both rival lines of work before naming their shared limit	P1 S2; P2 S1–S4
6- Stakes	Cost: the closure drains energy from scales that are gaining it, stated as physics. Benefit: closures can be tested where they are most likely to fail	P1 S3; P3 S2
7- Doubts answered	Not present in the introduction	–
8- Contribution	A local diagnostic of the sign and size of interscale transfer, named as a tool	P3 S1
9- Structure	Problem (P1), prior work that sharpens it (P2), contribution (P3); explanation deferred to Section 2; error model: both approaches share a flaw	P1–P3; P3 S3; P2 S4
10- Pitfalls	None of the four checks found. Background opening: the first instability word, “incomplete,” is in P1. No aim or interest sentence; no novelty claim; results without consequence does not apply to an introduction	P1 S2

Self-check (fields 1–12)

Field	Status	Evidence and fix move
1- Readers	STRONG	Research community named in the first words; rival communities named in P2 (P1 S1; P2 S2–S3)
2- Value words	STRONG	Instability words in every paragraph of the problem (P1 S2–S3; P2 S2–S4)
3- Value offered	STRONG	Offered as something modelers can do (P3 S2; M1)
4- Problem	STRONG	All three parts stated: current state, where it breaks, what remains open (P1 S1–S4; P2 S2–S4)
5- Stance	STRONG	Credits both lines of work before naming their shared limit (P2 S1–S4; M9)
6- Stakes	PARTIAL	The cost is stated as physics, not as a cost to these readers. Say what misplaced transfer does to the predictions they care about (M2, M10)
7- Doubts answered	MISSING	No doubt is anticipated. Name the doubt modelers will raise, such as whether an a priori diagnostic says anything about a posteriori runs, and say where the paper answers it (M4)
8- Contribution	STRONG	Named as a tool these readers can use (P3 S1; M1)
9- Structure	STRONG	Problem, then prior work that sharpens it, then contribution; definitions deferred to Section 2 (M8, M7)
10- Pitfalls	STRONG	None of the four checks found; the results check does not apply to an introduction
11- Value count	STRONG	Nine distinct value words in P1–P2
12- Opening	PARTIAL	P1 S1 states the readers' practice, but the question the paper answers (where is my closure wrong?) first appears in P2 S4. Bring a version of it into P1 (M8)

Priority fix: 6- Stakes. Readers can see that the model is wrong, but not yet what it costs them. Doubts answered (7-) is missing too, but readers who can't see the cost stop reading before their doubts matter.

7 Worksheet ADDED

Text analyzed _____

Mode Dissect / Self-check

Readers (L1) _____

ID	Finding (what the text does)	Location	Status	Fix move (self-check)
L1				
L2				
L3				
L4				
L5				
L6				
L7				
L8				
L9				
L10				
L11				
L12				

Status is for self-check only; leave it blank when dissecting (R3). L11 and L12 apply to your own draft.

Reusable frames (L2): _____

_____

Priority fix (self-check): _____

8 Report Format for Skills and Reviewers ADDED

Reports produced from this handout, by a person or by a skill, use this layout so they can be compared and cited. A skill writes it in ordinary chat formatting: bold labels and a table, not a code block.

```
McEnerney-lens report - Dissect | Self-check
Text      : title, venue, sections read
Readers   : research community; wider readers
Labels    : "1- Readers" to "12- Opening", never the IDs; cells up to
            about 60 words, "4- Problem" about 40 for each of its parts

DISSECT    : table | Field | What the paper does | Where |, rows 1- to 10-,
             then tables "2- Value words in context" and "10- Pitfalls"
             "Not present" and "stated only in Sec. n" are facts; no statuses

SELF-CHECK : the same two tables, then | Field | Status | Evidence and fix move |
             one row per field, 1- to 12-: STRONG|PARTIAL|MISSING|N/A,
             evidence with its location, fix (M<n>)
             Priority fix: the one field that most limits value, and why
             Untouched   : numbers, results and technical claims are not changed

Where     : section, paragraph and the sentence's first words (R2)
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9 References

[1] L. McEnerney, *Leadership Lab: The Craft of Writing Effectively*, lecture, University of Chicago Writing Program. Recording posted by UChicago Social Sciences on YouTube, 26 June 2014. https://youtu.be/vtIzMaLkCaM

[2] W. H. Sewell Jr., "Historical events as transformations of structures: Inventing revolution at the Bastille," *Theory and Society*, 25(6), 841–881, 1996. doi:10.1007/BF00159818. (The "Ever since Herodotus" opening: a problem built in the first paragraph, with its two reader communities named.)

[3] J. Tutino, "The revolution in Mexican independence: Insurgency and the renegotiation of property, production, and patriarchy in the Bajío, 1800–1855," *Hispanic American Historical Review*, 78(3), 367ff., August 1998. (An opening that directly challenges an entrenched view; its first footnote shows readers helping the author find his problem.)

[4] E. W. Said, *Orientalism*, Pantheon Books, 1978. (Its introduction is McEnerney's extended example of a writer defining several communities of readers.)

[5] J.-F. Lyotard, *The Postmodern Condition: A Report on Knowledge* (1979), trans. G. Bennington and B. Massumi, Manchester University Press, 1984, section 1. (The passage on knowledge becoming exterior to the knower and taking the form of a commodity.)

[6] L. Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations*, Blackwell, 1953. (McEnerney's "what something means is what it does": meaning as use.)

[7] R. C. Vrijenhoek, "Factors affecting clonal diversity and coexistence," *American Zoologist*, 19, 787–797, 1979. (Background to the frozen niche-variation model named in the lecture's 1A/1B biology example; the two example paragraphs are teaching texts.)

[8] W. C. Booth, G. G. Colomb and J. M. Williams, *The Craft of Research*, University of Chicago Press (4th ed., 2016, with J. Bizup and W. T. FitzGerald). (Further reading, not named in the lecture: Colomb and Williams developed the course McEnerney teaches, and the book treats research problems at length.)

Not identified in the recording: the "why people write essays" passage McEnerney criticizes (he calls it a caricature written for high-school students) [44:29–49:22], and the economists' introduction he praises on pages 16–17 of his printed handout [1:14:34–1:15:34].

See also: Handout 2 (*effective-writing*) applies the same reader-value idea to single paragraphs.